

THE AUTHORITATIVE GUIDE TO **BUILDING YOUR BANKROLL**

We've found that, besides a strong game, the biggest reason people can't count cards is because they do not have a bankroll or do not know proper bankroll management. This guide, along with our Bankroll Management Tool, are designed to make sure this isn't a factor for you. If you're looking to grow a bankroll from meager beginnings like we did, this guide will provide you with tested and proven ways to build your bankroll

DON'T GAMBLE

Seriously. We aren't interested in gambling. We're interested in using "advantage play" to invest our money at the blackjack tables. We are all for taking calculated (sometimes high) risks. But this is different from gambling. I would define gambling as "risking money at a disadvantage, hoping (against the odds) to get lucky." Some people want to try to defy the odds to build their bankroll. We don't recommend that. It will reinforce bad habits at best, and in more than one case, I've seen it result in people losing more than they can afford to lose (financially, emotionally, and relationally). It destroys lives, is dumb, and I hate seeing casinos have the last laugh. Please. Don't. Gamble.

FREEBIES, MATCHPLAYS, PROMO CHIPS

Casinos are constantly giving out freebies to get you in the door. The EV might not be phenomenal for a \$10 matchplay (worth about 40-80% of face value), but the risk is REALLY low. I once knew a guy who got into card counting because a local casino sent out a \$25 matchplay in a local news publication every day. He (and his girlfriend) would go twice a day and each use the matchplay. Within a couple months, they had generated enough EV to buy an inexpensive car and start their first blackjack bankroll (they went on to win enough money counting cards to retire to Europe). If you've read Ben's e-book, you know that we won \$10,000 off of \$5 swimsuit calendars... each calendar had loads of matchplays and "free Ace" coupons on the back. I've known several crews of card counters who have lived off of matchplay runs, hitting each casino in their area every week, exploiting the casinos' advertising offers.

TOURNAMENTS

I'll be honest with you. In my opinion, this isn't the most exciting way to build a bankroll. But if you have more time than money, lots of casinos offer Blackjack, Slot, and Poker tournaments with free entry. The tournament takes forever, so the casino assumes it will get people to gamble in-between rounds. But if you DON'T waste money you don't have between rounds and only play the FREE tournaments, you might get fortunate enough to make some money at one of these tourneys. (I know a guy that got his entry into a Blackjack tournament comped, so he thought it would be fun to try. He ended up winning the 1st Place \$15,000 prize, and instantly had a sizable bankroll!)

GET A PERFECT GAME

The nice thing about the last two points is that you don't have to be a proficient card counter to get started. However, before you start playing for real, do yourself a favor and wait for your game to be PERFECT. I know you didn't get into card counting to deal cards to yourself at home. But I've seen too many amateur card counters lose their bankroll because of shoddy play. Yes, you can make serious money with card counting, but our edge is small; ANY mistakes will rule out your advantage. Here are 4 things you should do before playing in a casino:

- ◆ Watch our entire [Video Course](#)...Twice. This is the content we used to train players of our team. And unfortunately, we find ourselves answering questions over and over again (on the forum and at Bootcamps) that we've dealt with in the Video Course.
- ◆ Be able to play perfectly (for hours and hours) on our Training Drills or iOS App. These drills are what we wish we would have had when we were training. You should be able to play 500 perfect hands on any and every drill. Anything less than that and you shouldn't spend your time in a casino.
- ◆ Spend several hours back-counting in a casino. I've already mentioned this in our [Card Counting Motivator Training Guide](#), but before you try sitting down at a table and doing everything at once, spend plenty of time just counting down a live dealer.
- ◆ Make sure you have a winning bet spread. You don't just need perfect play. You also need a bet spread that will give you a profit. Don't skip this step. You can get started by reading [this article](#), or if you want help, we provide custom bankroll coaching to people who have our [Starter Membership](#).

TEAM UP WITH OTHERS

I admit this one is risky. If you team up with someone who is more skilled or less skilled than you at card counting, it's going to be a bad team. But if you have a friend who you trust 100%, and you are 100% trustworthy, consider training together, pooling your resources, and making a go of it! When I put my \$4,000 bankroll together with Ben's \$7,000, we were each able to bet off of a \$11K bankroll! That meant we could each bet more, generating more EV/hour. As we both won, our bankroll grew twice as fast! Again, it's more important to team up with the RIGHT person. But I've always benefitted financially and relationally by playing off a joint bankroll with close friends.

PROMOTIONS, GIVEAWAYS, AND GRAND OPENINGS

Not only do some casinos offer matchplays and promo chips, but occasionally you'll find a casino with other promotions going on. I know of a few casinos that (foolishly) offered 2:1 on ALL blackjacks for the week of their Grand Opening. This gave the player such a huge advantage that there was no need to bother counting cards. Just sit there, bet as much as your bankroll can handle, and enjoy a 2% edge. Another chain of casinos near us offered a "Happy Hour" promotion where that gave the player an advantage on anything above a true -1. We knew card counters who grew their bankrolls from 4 figures to 6 figures using playing the "happy hour" promotion every day. And even though these promotions are rare, lots of casinos offer giveaways at certain times for being in the seat that gets called. Obviously, the best time to play is while the giveaway is being offered. Or if they pick the person in the "lucky seat" every hour, then be there at 3AM when there are only 5 people in the casino. Then you have a 20% chance of being selected!

ONLY WONG IN

What if I told you there is a way to lower risk while simultaneously increasing your win rate? Well there is, and it's called "wonging." Wonging is the strategy of watching the blackjack tables (standing behind the table, counting down the shoe) until the player has the advantage, then joining the game only when it's to your advantage to play. On the average blackjack game, everything below a true 1 is negative EV, so it's costing you money. If you don't have a sizeable bankroll to play with, avoid negative EV all together by back-counting and wonging in at a true 1. This will lower your risk and variance a TON and increase your EV. We used this a lot when we first started and still use the strategy a lot because, why not! Some people say that it's awkward standing behind the table watching. I have 2 responses to this:

- ◆ Take a look around the casino. You're likely not the most interesting person in the room.
- ◆ Get over it! Nothing about being a card counter is comfortable. We're there to beat the game, and that involves stepping outside our comfort zones.

Wonging may be tedious, but it's one of the smartest ways to keep your risk low on a small bankroll... let the suckers play when the casino has the advantage.

DON'T TIP

This is likely the most unpopular item on this list. Tipping makes dealers happy (for about 5 seconds), which makes us feel good about ourselves (for about 10 seconds). But it's bad business. I've known many card counters tip away their entire advantage. You just won \$100, so what's a \$10 tip? Possibly your entire EV for the last hour! If you're there to make money, you have to make smart business decisions. Let the players who are there to spend money take care of the dealer. If you have a large enough bankroll can afford to tip the dealer \$5 here or there, go for it. But you don't want to shoot your career in the foot by inadvertently giving away your hard earned bankroll. If you're there for a good time, that's fine. But if you're going to say that you're there to make money, it has to fit into your business plan.

SAVE MONEY

Yeah, it's more exciting to grow a bankroll from the casino's coffers. But sometimes you have to be patient and save up money outside the casinos to grow a bankroll. If you're looking to make some serious money from card counting, it helps to think about it like starting a business. Don't be the guy who's perpetually "building his bankroll" to start counting cards professionally. Save your money, and when you've got enough saved up and your skills are sharp, go for it! It's basically universal that card counters are cheapskates. We don't waste money, and we use the money that we've saved to make us more money. My wife and I lived off of her meager income for the first 6 months of my card counting career. But that allowed us to grow my \$2,000 bankroll into a \$50,000 bankroll in 6 months. Consider passing on the new toys and eat out less so you can put aside a few hundred bucks each month towards a serious bankroll. Plenty of financial gurus like to say that you should aggressively cut your spending on things you don't really care about so that you can spend aggressively on the things you do care about.

Card counting isn't for the faint of heart. It takes hustle, fearlessness, patience, and dedication. But what good thing doesn't? If you create a plan and are smart about it, I guarantee you will get there and you can make serious money from card counting. But without a bankroll, you end up being [this guy](#).